

The Business of Healing



India's private hospital sector is witnessing an unprecedented boom. Leading chains such as Manipal, Apollo, Max Healthcare, Medanta, and Fortis, among others, are pumping in more than ₹40,000 crore to add capacity by 2030. Foreign investors and private equity giants are increasingly taking over healthcare chains, which in turn are building new facilities, acquiring regional outfits to stitch together larger hospital networks.

Behind this expansion spree lies a story of rising profitability and growing investor conviction in the business of healing. India's listed hospital chains are posting record revenues and profits. Over the past decade, the combined gross sales of Nifty Hospital Index companies have surged 247%, while profits have risen 15-fold in FY26.

In this issue's cover story, *Neetu Chandra Sharma* maps the many contours of the healthcare gold rush. The results are evident in better healthcare access, especially in Tier II and Tier III cities, but so are the concerns around the cost of treatment and inflated hospital bills, as well as a shortage of skilled healthcare professionals.

At the heart of this expansion is a distinct phenomenon—the Doctorpreneur. These are highly trained and motivated specialists who have moved beyond clinical practice to become entrepreneurs, building institutions that seek to address problems they had encountered first-hand in the Indian healthcare system.

From Dr. Prathap C. Reddy's creation of Apollo after witnessing the consequences of inadequate cardiac infrastructure to Dr. Devi Shetty's pursuit of affordable heart care, these founders built institutions that have attracted both talent and capital. Renowned cardiac surgeon Dr. Naresh Trehan, who also writes in this edition, represents another strand of that endeavour through Medanta, with its focus on advanced, multi-speciality care. Then there is Dr. Ramesh Kancharla, whose Rainbow Children's Hospital offers specialised paediatric care, and Dr. Dharminder Nagar, who took organised healthcare to underserved cities outside the metros. A younger generation, including orthopaedic surgeon Dr. Aashish Chaudhry, is also betting that doctor-led hospitals can combine affordability with scale and reach, not just in the country but overseas as well.

Affordability, however, remains the troubling reality in India's healthcare story. As *Surabhi* highlights, even as government spending and insurance coverage expand, households continue to shoulder a substantial medical burden. The real challenge is to ensure that out-of-pocket healthcare expenditure falls.

Apart from doctors, nurses and other hospital staff, India's medical tourism economy also rests on translators and cultural mediators. *Karan Dhar* met up with individuals who bridge language and cultural gaps between international patients and Indian healthcare providers. Their work includes airport pick-ups, accommodation, admission paperwork, emotional support, and crisis management. For a patient far from home, these are the people who represent the face of Indian healthcare.

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